

Read **Text C**, and then answer **Questions 2(a)–(d)** and **Question 3** on the question paper.

Text C: Paddling Alaska

The writer, Audrey Sutherland, worked for years as a careers adviser for high school students before setting off on her first solo kayaking trip through Alaska. Since that first trip she has paddled more than 13 000 solo Alaskan kilometres.

I first saw southern Alaska from the air, looking down on islands with secluded beaches and hidden inlets, huge trees and a point for watching sunrise and sunset.

Fifteen kilometres from any town was wilderness; towns were dotted far apart. That left lots of space to paddle, explore and camp. Since 1967, whenever I could squeeze in a vacation, I'd been voyaging in inflatable kayaks. I'd written a fairly successful book about my trips around Hawaiian islands. Paddling through Alaska was top of my 25-morale-building-things-to-do list. My publisher was also keen.

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Looking at the map, my choice was clear: I could paddle direct along established routes for fishing boats, or go 'gunkholing', as boaters say, prowling in and out of tiny coves and meandering south. Connecting a roundabout route of hot springs, old cabins, the smallest islets and resupply towns, I could trace excerpts of historic voyages, forage natural delicacies and communicate with such endearing animals as whales and otters. I wasn't yet factoring in grizzly bears.

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This second route would be over 800 miles and involve crossing open sea and dangerous straits. Obviously, I'd go gunkholing.

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My inflatable kayak would be the smallest boat to attempt this distance, an impertinent toy compared to the crafted cedar-log-dugout canoes paddled for centuries along these misty shores, or sturdy modern fibreglass canoes.

'You're seriously paddling 800 miles in Alaska in that?' said a man on a beach one day. 'Where's the unicorn head and mermaid flippers to go with it?'

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He sneered at the limp, shapeless roll of plastic on the sand. I attached the hose of the air pump to a valve in the newly patched intrepid vessel and the plastic kayak squirmed slowly and reluctantly out of its wrinkles into a tube shape. I kept pumping. The second side and the hull gradually assumed a wonky banana shape, a bit like a boat-shaped doughnut, bright yellow with ridiculously optimistic red-and-white 'racing stripes' down the sides.

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Why use this boat? Well, I already owned it. It would roll up in a small bag that I could take on the plane. I'd paddled enough rough seas in it to know it was seaworthy. Above all, it was light enough to carry by myself up the beach above high tide each night.

My yellow colour scheme was reinforced when my order of foul-weather gear arrived. I tried it on, laughing at my incongruous image in the mirror. 'Getting older aren't you?'

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I'd asked for two months off work to complete the trip. I wanted to be lean, hard and kind. Instead I felt soft, fat and mean. Years of a desk job can do that. After decades spent helping others decide what to do with their lives, I wondered whether I knew what to do with mine.

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During the next weeks I booked cabins where I could stay for 10 of the 80 nights of the trip. I mailed my camping essentials to excited friends living near my launching point, and sent resupply boxes of dried food addressed to myself at post offices en route, with notes to the incredulous post masters to 'hold for paddling expedition to arrive approx. (date)'. I dutifully made copies of the daily route so my grown-up family would know where to start their search if I didn't check in along the way and made notches on one side of my pencil to measure a nautical mile on some of the ocean charts.

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My request for leave came back, unapproved.

I resigned.

And the bear? Well that was actually years later. Beginning this first Alaskan adventure, I'd have been relieved to know that any bears and I would avoid each other. Every Alaskan has a bear story. Should I start with mine? 'The grizzly bear stood one metre away, his enormous muzzle visible through the plastic sheet over the cabin window ...' Nah, I'll tell you about that later.

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